

Career Portfolio Project Plan for Finance and Data Roles in London

To reach £50k-£60k in London, you should aim for roles like:

Target role	Realistic salary direction
SQL Data Analyst	around £55k median in UK job ads
Senior Data Analyst	around £60k median in UK job ads
SQL/Power BI Developer	often around £50k+ in London
BI Analyst / BI Developer	can reach £50k-£60k+ with strong Power BI + SQL
Finance Data Analyst	often stronger pay if you know finance concepts too

Current London/UK salary sources show the target is realistic but usually not for a very basic junior analyst portfolio. For example, IT Jobs Watch lists SQL Data Analyst median salary at about £55k, and Senior Data Analyst at about £60k. Robert Half lists London Data Analyst salary ranges roughly from £44.5k to £77.25k, while Morgan McKinley shows London Data Analyst averages around £65k-£80k depending on seniority and role complexity.

So your project should not look like:

"I made a dashboard."

It should look like:

"I solved a business/finance problem using Excel, SQL, Python, Power BI, and clear commercial thinking."

Best project to do: Finance Performance Analytics Project

This would be my top recommendation for you.

Project title

Financial Performance & Risk Dashboard for a Lending / Investment Business

This project works well for finance, but also transfers to fintech, banking, insurance, retail, consulting, operations, and SaaS companies.

What the project should include

You create a fake but realistic finance dataset, or use public data, then build a full analysis pipeline:

Raw data -> SQL database -> Python cleaning/analysis -> Power BI dashboard -> business recommendations

The project should answer business questions like:

1. Which customers/products generate the most revenue?
2. Which customers are risky or unprofitable?
3. How is revenue changing month by month?
4. What is the default rate / late payment rate?
5. Which customer segments have the best return?
6. What should the business do next?

Why this project is strong

Because it shows the exact mix employers like:

Skill	How your project proves it
Excel	initial exploration, pivot tables, finance calculations
SQL	database, joins, aggregations, CTEs, window functions
Python	cleaning, automation, analysis
Power BI	dashboard and business reporting
Finance thinking	revenue, margin, risk, default, profitability
Communication	README, insights, recommendations

That combination is much stronger than only doing SQL or only doing Power BI.

Recommended project structure

Your GitHub folder could look like this:

```

finance-performance-analytics/
|
|-- README.md
|-- data/
|   |-- raw/
|   |   |-- customers.csv
|   |   |-- loans.csv
|   |   |-- payments.csv
|   |   |-- products.csv
|   |
|   |-- cleaned/
|       |-- finance_cleaned.csv
|
|-- sql/
|   |-- 01_create_schema.sql
|   |-- 02_import_data.sql
|   |-- 03_revenue_analysis.sql
|   |-- 04_customer_risk_analysis.sql
|   |-- 05_monthly_trends.sql
|   |-- 06_profitability_analysis.sql
|
|-- python/
|   |-- data_cleaning.ipynb
|   |-- exploratory_analysis.ipynb
|
|-- powerbi/
|   |-- finance_dashboard.pbix
|
|-- excel/
|   |-- initial_analysis.xlsx
|
|-- insights.md

```

What the database could contain

Use tables like:

```

customers
loans
payments
products
branches

```

Example:

customers

```
customer_id
age
income
employment_status
region
credit_score
```

loans

```
loan_id
customer_id
loan_amount
interest_rate
loan_term_months
loan_start_date
loan_status
```

payments

```
payment_id
loan_id
payment_date
amount_due
amount_paid
days_late
```

products

```
product_id
product_name
product_type
risk_category
```

This gives you enough data to show real business analysis.

SQL questions to answer

You could write queries like:

1. Monthly revenue

```
SELECT
    DATE_TRUNC('month', payment_date) AS month,
    SUM(amount_paid) AS monthly_revenue
FROM payments
GROUP BY month
ORDER BY month;
```

2. Late payment rate

```
SELECT
    COUNT(*) AS total_payments,
    SUM(CASE WHEN days_late > 0 THEN 1 ELSE 0 END) AS late_payments,
    ROUND(
        SUM(CASE WHEN days_late > 0 THEN 1 ELSE 0 END) * 100.0 / COUNT(*),
        2
    ) AS late_payment_rate
FROM payments;
```

3. Risk by customer segment

```
SELECT
    c.employment_status,
    c.region,
    COUNT(DISTINCT c.customer_id) AS customers,
    AVG(c.credit_score) AS avg_credit_score,
    AVG(p.days_late) AS avg_days_late
```

```

FROM customers c
JOIN loans l
    ON c.customer_id = l.customer_id
JOIN payments p
    ON l.loan_id = p.loan_id
GROUP BY c.employment_status, c.region
ORDER BY avg_days_late DESC;

```

4. Most profitable customer groups

```

SELECT
    c.region,
    c.employment_status,
    SUM(p.amount_paid) AS total_revenue,
    AVG(l.interest_rate) AS avg_interest_rate,
    COUNT(DISTINCT l.loan_id) AS number_of_loans
FROM customers c
JOIN loans l
    ON c.customer_id = l.customer_id
JOIN payments p
    ON l.loan_id = p.loan_id
GROUP BY c.region, c.employment_status
ORDER BY total_revenue DESC;

```

Power BI dashboard pages

Your Power BI report could have 4 pages:

Page	What it shows
Executive Summary	revenue, profit, default rate, late payment rate
Customer Analysis	age, income, region, customer segments
Risk Analysis	credit score, late payments, default patterns
Product Performance	which loan/product types perform best

Use KPIs like:

- Total Revenue
- Average Loan Amount
- Late Payment Rate
- Default Rate
- Revenue by Month
- Revenue by Region
- Top Customer Segments
- Risk by Credit Score Band

Add finance/business logic

This is what will make the project look more "£50k-£60k level."

Do not only show charts. Add business interpretation.

For example:

Insight:

Customers with credit scores below 580 had a late payment rate of 28%, compared with 9% for customers

Recommendation:

The business should either reduce approval limits for this group, increase pricing to reflect risk, or

Another example:

Insight:

London and South East customers generated the highest revenue, but also had higher average loan balance

Recommendation:

The business should separate revenue growth from risk-adjusted profitability before increasing marketi

That sounds much more like a finance analyst, risk analyst, or commercial analyst.

Best 3 portfolio projects for your goal

I would build 3 projects, not 10 small ones.

Project 1: Finance Performance & Risk Analytics

Best for:

Finance Data Analyst
Risk Analyst
Credit Analyst
BI Analyst in banking/fintech
Commercial Analyst

Tools:

SQL + Python + Power BI + Excel

This should be your main project.

Project 2: Sales & Profitability Analytics for a Retail Business

Best for:

BI Analyst
Commercial Analyst
Revenue Analyst
Operations Analyst
Category Analyst

Questions:

Which products generate the most profit?
Which customers are most valuable?
Which regions underperform?
Which months are strongest?
Where should the business reduce costs?

This project is useful because not every good job is in finance. Retail, SaaS, logistics, and consulting also hire analysts.

Project 3: Stock Market / Portfolio Analytics Project

Best for:

Investment Analyst Assistant
Finance Analyst
Data Analyst in asset management
Trading operations analyst

You could analyse:

FTSE 100 stocks
S&P 500 stocks
portfolio returns
volatility
moving averages
drawdowns
correlation between assets

But be careful: a stock dashboard alone can look too common. Make it more analytical by adding:

risk-adjusted return

volatility
benchmark comparison
sector allocation
portfolio drawdown

My recommended order

Do them in this order:

1. Finance Performance & Risk Analytics
2. Sales & Profitability Analytics
3. Stock / Portfolio Analytics

The first one is the strongest for your salary target.

Skills you should show to reach £50k-£60k

For that salary range, you want to show more than beginner skills.

SQL

Show:

JOINS
LEFT JOINS
GROUP BY
CASE WHEN
CTEs
window functions
date calculations
data cleaning
primary keys / foreign keys

Power BI

Show:

data model
relationships
DAX measures
KPIs
filters/slicers
professional dashboard design

Python

Show:

pandas
data cleaning
basic charts
automation
CSV/database connection

Finance knowledge

Show:

revenue
profit
margin
risk
default rate
late payment rate
customer segmentation
forecasting basics

The project that gives you the best chance

Build this:

End-to-End Finance Risk & Profitability Analytics Project

With this headline on GitHub/LinkedIn:

Built an end-to-end finance analytics project using SQL, Python, Excel, and Power BI to analyse loan p

That sounds much stronger than:

I made a Power BI dashboard.

Important truth

A project alone will not guarantee £50k-£60k, especially if you are applying for junior roles. But a strong end-to-end project can help you apply for better roles such as:

SQL Data Analyst
BI Analyst
Finance Data Analyst
Commercial Analyst
Risk Analyst
Reporting Analyst
Power BI Developer

Those are much closer to your salary target than generic "junior data analyst" roles.